daily by his intelligence chiefs and instead asked them to brief his national security adviser. [49]

The emergence of the national security adviser has created a new centre of power in addition to the Prime Minister's Office and the Ministry of External Affairs. The national security adviser is an all-round adviser to the prime minister. He handles foreign and security policy as well as domestic issues. As the key foreign policy adviser to the prime minister, the NSA participates in all high-level talks and often accompanies the prime minister on his foreign visits. An example of the role of the NSA in such talks was the start of conversations between India and the US on the civil nuclear deal. The idea of the India–US nuclear deal, for example, originated during a conversation between Indian NSA Brajesh Mishra and his US counterpart, Condoleezza Rice.

Direct and constant access to the prime minister enables the national security adviser to be better informed about current events than even the minister for external affairs. The creation of the office of the NSA has resulted in an erosion of authority for both the foreign secretary and the external affairs minister, which is what the permanent civil service feared all along. It has, however, paved the way for better coordination between different branches of government and made decision making as well as implementation easier. Critics argue, however, that the concept of national security adviser is better suited for a presidential system of government than a parliamentary one.

The national security adviser does not have any executive authority and can only advise the prime minister. In India the national security adviser is, in the view of critics, simply an extension of prime ministerial intrusion into affairs of the foreign ministry.[50] The first NSA, Brajesh Mishra, was principal secretary to the prime minister, in addition to being national security adviser, and therefore carried weight within the bureaucratic structure. His successors, however, have had to invoke the authority of the